

HOTHOUSE OF TALENT Danisius Manih, who is hearing impaired, was trained in agriculture and works as a field assistant in Shillong

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Its Jyoti Sroat School became inclusive from 2006, as children with and without disabilities started studying together**
- **Works across health, livelihood and social inclusion, following a community-based approach**
- **Partners with organisations across the Northeast, sharing programmes and building capacity**

blind, deaf or intellectually challenged. What started as healthcare expanded into disability-focused intervention. By the mid-1980s, Bethany had shifted base to Tura and, in 1992, opened the Jyoti Sroat School and Roilang Livelihood Academy in Shillong, to promote education and vocational training.

"When the school began in the early 1990s, disability awareness was minimal in Meghalaya," recalls Bertha G. Dkhar, Bethany's executive director, who is herself visually impaired. "When I, a blind Khasi woman, joined the school, I was ridiculed. The school started with just eight students. Many dropped out. Only two from the first batch cleared Class 10. But a decade later, when students began passing board exams, public opinion shifted."

The turning point came in 2006, when Jyoti Sroat became fully inclusive. Children with and without disabilities study together and follow the same state syllabus. What differs is the support: blind students use digital tools, deaf students work with sign language interpreters, autistic students follow flexible learning timelines.

The move was not welcomed initially. When Bethany first proposed such inclusion, government officials warned it would lower educational standards. That same year, Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan was rolled out nationally, and Jyoti Sroat was later recognised by the education department as a model school.

Alongside the school, Bethany follows a community-based development approach, working across health, education, livelihoods, social inclusion and empowerment. Bethany also links persons with disabilities and marginalised families to existing government schemes, focusing on access, facilitation and advocacy.

Bethany's operational focus remains within Meghalaya, but it partners with organisations across the Northeast to share programmes and build capacity. Once programmes stabilise, they are handed over or supported to function independently, allowing the organisation to move into new areas of need.

Today, Bethany operates through a combination of institutional services and village-level programmes, all grounded in the belief that systems must adapt to people—not the other way around. ■

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"Before Bethany, I used to cry on the roadside every morning as other children went to school. In Bethany, I learned I was not worthless. It gave me the tools to live, to defend myself, and to uplift others"

PYNHOI TANG, *Visually-impaired former student*